purposes. They had also moved forward their boats used for patrolling the lake from Finger 8 to Finger 5 and built floating jetties. At this point, it should be remembered that the PLA was on the lower reaches of Finger 4, while the IA was in containment positions on Finger 3. The PLA proposed that they would move back from Finger 4 to Finger 5, while we should move back from Finger 3 to our Dhan Singh Thapa (DST) Post, which is about halfway between Fingers 2 and 3. This was a totally unacceptable proposal. We reiterated our stance that reversion to the status quo ante of April 2020 was the only way forward. The PLA once again expressed concern at our build-up and made five recommendations namely, de-escalation (not disengagement) along isolated areas; de-escalation to be based on mutual equal security (which was our stance); respect LAC claims; stop fresh induction of troops; and maintain good channels of communication.

From time to time, I would brief the PM. My MA would get a call from the PMO, usually Shri Sanjay Bhavsar (OSD—Appointment and Tour), asking for my availability and saying that the PM wanted to meet me. This would be followed by another call from one of the JSs or Directors asking for the Agenda. The first time this happened, I conveyed that it was the PM who had summoned me and there was no agenda as such. No matter, came the response, whatever you intend to say, please send a write-up on each point. While the crisis in Eastern Ladakh was ongoing, it was the main agenda of the interaction, but at other times, I had to rack my mind to see what were the issues worth bringing to the notice of the PM at a one-on-one level. Transitioning to Integrated Battle Groups (IBG), for example, or the challenges in implementing the Supreme Court orders on granting Permanent Commission to Women Officers.

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation